Client Name: Date:

RDN/NDTR: Email: Phone:

General, Healthful Nutrition Therapy

This handout provides you with the information you'll need to follow a general, healthful diet, which can be tailored to your personal preferences.

There are several benefits to following a general, healthful diet:

- It could mean less calories, less salt, less added sugars, and less saturated fat than many other diets. This outcome will depend on the foods you choose.
- Eating more whole grains, beans, lentils, fruits, vegetables, nuts, and seeds may improve how much fiber, vitamins, and minerals you eat.
- It can lower your risk for health conditions like diabetes, heart disease, hypertension, stroke, and cancer.

Your registered dietitian nutritionist (RDN) may recommend portion sizes based on your individual needs and personal and cultural preferences.

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Tips

- Every day, eat a variety of fruits and vegetables in a variety of colors.
  - Be sure to include lots of dark green, red, blue-purple, and orange vegetables.
- Choose whole grains for at least half of your grain selections.
- Eat more beans, peas, and lentils.
- Try meatless alternatives.
  - Get protein in your diet from eggs, fish, poultry, beans, peas, lentils, and nuts/nut butters.
  - Low-fat or fat-free dairy products are also good sources of protein.
- Keep your salt intake to a minimum (less than 2300 milligrams per day).
  - Limit use of salt, soy sauce, or fish sauce when cooking.
  - Eat freshly prepared meals at home. Processed, prepackaged, and restaurant foods contain more salt.
  - Choose fresh fruits and vegetables for snacks.
  - Choose products with lower sodium content when grocery shopping.
- Limit your daily sugar intake.
  - Sugar may be used in sauces, marinades, dressings, and condiments – even those that do not taste sweet.
  - Sugar can be found in honey, syrups, jelly, fruit juice, and fruit juice concentrate.
  - Limit sugar-sweetened beverages like sodas and fruit juice, sugary snacks, and candy.
  - It's best to choose products without added sugar, but if you do eat them, read labels carefully so you know how much sugar is in each portion.
- It is better to eat unsaturated fats than saturated fats.
  - Use fats and oils in moderation, up to 5 servings per day.
  - Unsaturated fat is found in fish, avocado, nuts, and oils like sunflower, canola, avocado and olive oils.
  - Saturated fat is found in fatty meat, butter, ice cream, palm and coconut oil, cream, cheese, and lard.
  - Many processed foods, fried foods, fast food items, convenience foods like frozen pizza and snack foods, and sweets including pies, cookies, and other pastries are high in fat. Check nutrition labels and choose these foods less often.
  - Use vegetable oil instead of lard or butter for cooking.
  - Boil, steam, or bake your food instead of deep frying in oil.
  - Remove the fatty part of meats before cooking.

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GENERAL, HEALTHFUL NUTRITION THERAPY (2022)

Foods to Choose or to Limit

Choose a healthful balance of foods from each food group at your meals. Your RDN may make individualized portion size recommendations based on your needs.

Food Group	Foods to Choose	Foods to Limit
Grains	▶ Whole wheat, barley, rye, buckwheat, corn, teff, quinoa, millet, amaranth, brown and wild rice, sorghum, and oats; focus on intact cooked whole grains ▶ Grain products, such as bread, rolls, prepared breakfast cereals, crackers, and pasta made from whole grains that are low in added sugars, saturated fat, and sodium	▶ Sweetened, low-fiber breakfast cereals ▶ Packaged (high sugar, refined ingredients) baked goods ▶ Snack crackers and chips made of refined ingredients, cheese crackers, butter crackers ▶ Breads made with refined ingredients and saturated fats, such as biscuits, frozen waffles, sweet breads, doughnuts, pastries, packaged baking mixes, pancakes, cakes, and cookies
Protein Foods	▶ Meat, including lean, trimmed cuts of beef, pork, or lamb a few times per week or less ▶ Poultry, including skinless chicken or turkey ▶ Seafood, including fish, shrimp, lobster, clams, and scallops at least twice per week. Focus on fatty fish, such as salmon, herring, and sardines, as a rich source of omega-3 fatty acids ▶ Eggs ▶ Nuts and seeds, such as peanuts, almonds, pistachios, and sunflower seeds (unsalted varieties) ▶ Nut and seed butters, such as peanut butter, almond butter, and sunflower seed butter (reduced-sodium varieties) ▶ Soy foods such as tofu, tempeh, or soy nuts ▶ Plant protein-based meat alternatives, such as veggie burgers and sausages (reduced-sodium varieties) ▶ Unsalted beans, lentils, or peas at least a few times per week in place of other protein sources	▶ Marbled or fatty red meats (beef, pork, lamb), such as ribs ▶ Processed red meats, such as bacon, sausage, and ham ▶ Poultry (chicken and turkey) with skin ▶ Fried meats, poultry, or fish ▶ King mackerel, shark, and tilefish (may contain high levels of mercury) ▶ Deli meats, such as pastrami, bologna, or salami ▶ Fried eggs ▶ Salted beans, peas, lentils, nuts, seeds, or nut/seed butters ▶ Meat alternatives with high levels of sodium or saturated fat
Dairy and Dairy Alternatives	▶ Low-fat or fat-free milk, yogurt (low in added sugars), cottage cheese, and cheeses ▶ Fortified soymilk or soy yogurt	▶ Whole milk, cream, cheeses made from whole milk, sour cream ▶ Yogurt or ice cream made from whole milk or with added sugar ▶ Cream cheese made from whole milk

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Food Group	Foods to Choose	Foods to Limit
Vegetables	▶ A variety of vegetables, including dark-green, red, blue-purple, and orange vegetables ▶ Low-sodium vegetable juices	▶ Canned or frozen vegetables with salt, fresh vegetables prepared with salt ▶ Fried vegetables ▶ Vegetables in cream sauce or cheese sauce ▶ Tomato or pasta sauce with high levels of salt or sugar
Fruit	▶ A variety of whole fruits, canned fruit packed in water, or dried fruit ▶ 100% fruit juice (limited to ½ cup per day)	▶ Fruits packed in syrup or made with added sugar
Fats and Oils	▶ Unsaturated vegetable oils, including olive, peanut, and canola oils ▶ Vegetable oil-based margarines and spreads ▶ Salad dressing and mayonnaise made from unsaturated vegetable oils	▶ Solid shortening or partially hydrogenated oils ▶ Solid margarine made with hydrogenated or partially hydrogenated oils ▶ Butter
Beverages	▶ Coffee and tea (unsweetened) ▶ Water	▶ Sweetened drinks, including sweetened coffee or tea drinks, soda, energy drinks, and sports drinks
Other	▶ Prepared foods, including soups, casseroles, salads, baked goods, and snacks made from recommended ingredients, with low levels of added saturated fat, added sugars, or salt	▶ Sugary and/or fatty desserts, candy, and other sweets; salt and seasonings that contain salt ▶ Fried foods

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General, Healthful Sample 1-Day Menu

Meal	Menu
Breakfast	■ 1 cup oatmeal ■ ½ cup blueberries ■ 1 ounce almonds ■ 1 cup 1% milk or fortified soymilk ■ 1 cup unsweetened coffee
Lunch	■ 2 slices whole wheat bread ■ 3 ounces turkey slices ■ 2 lettuce leaves ■ 2 slices tomato ■ 1 ounce reduced-fat, reduced sodium cheese ■ ½ cup carrot sticks ■ ¼ cup hummus ■ 1 banana ■ 1 cup 1% milk or fortified soymilk ■ 1 cup unsweetened tea
Dinner	■ 4 ounces salmon, baked ■ ½ cup cooked brown rice ■ 1 cup green beans, cooked ■ 1 cup mixed greens salad ■ 1 teaspoon olive oil mixed with vinegar of choice ■ 1 whole wheat roll ■ 1 teaspoon margarine, soft, tub (for roll) ■ 1 cup water
Snack	■ 1 cup low-fat yogurt ■ ½ cup peach slices

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Sample Meal Plan

Use this form to create an individualized meal plan.

Meal	Menu
Breakfast	
Lunch	
Dinner	
Snack	

Notes:

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